

PAKISTAN:

Tens of thousands displaced by army operations against insurgent groups

A profile of the internal displacement situation

10 October, 2006

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OVERVIEW

Tens of thousands displaced by army operations against insurgent groups

Army operations targeting insurgent groups in Waziristan and Balochistan are the main causes of conflict-induced displacement in Pakistan today. There is no official information on the number of people displaced and access of journalists and aid workers to the affected areas is tightly restricted. But best estimates from the media and aid agencies are that at the very least many tens of thousands of people have been forced to flee their homes in both areas, though most of these will have returned home within a matter of weeks.

In Balochistan, the fighting has been between tribal rebels and the army. Apart from longstanding demands for increased political autonomy, development projects are fuelling the current conflict in Balochistan as the local population demands increased control over and more benefits from the exploitation of natural resources. The current unrest started in 2003 and has intensified during 2005 and 2006, bringing 40,000 army troops to the region to fight local militant groups. Estimates of the number displaced at its peak are as high as 200,000.

In Waziristan, a government-led operation started in March 2004 against militants connected to Taleban and al-Qaeda hiding on the Pakistan side of the border. Since then, search operations and fighting between rebel groups and the army have displaced an unknown number of civilians. As many as 80,000 army troops are deployed along the border with Afghanistan. The presidents of the two countries swap accusations of not doing enough to prevent Taleban and al-Qaeda activities along the border.

Despite the large numbers displaced due to the conflicts, humanitarian aid from outsiders has been rejected so far. As no one is allowed in to assess the situation in the conflict-affected areas, it is not possible to verify the little information that has trickled out about the displaced populations. However, both national and international actors must insist that the conflict-affected populations be granted basic assistance and protection during displacement, as well as a safe and voluntary return to their homes when the situation permits.

Internal displacement in South Waziristan

Waziristan is divided into two "agencies", North Waziristan and South Waziristan, with estimated populations (as of 1998) of 361,246 and 429,841 respectively. North Waziristan is mainly inhabited by farming Wazir tribes, and South Waziristan by two Pashtun tribes, Wazir and Mahsud. Waziristan belongs to the seven Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) bordering Afghanistan. The tribal areas are indirectly governed by political agents – a system that was created by the former British rulers. In practice, central government rarely exerted direct control beyond the main roads and towns, with traditional tribal structures ruling everywhere else in the territory. The Waziri tribes have maintained close relations for centuries with other Waziris living across the British-drawn border in Afghanistan.

Sources: Rediff.com, 7 April 2004; Wikipedia Encyclopedia

The conflict in Waziristan began in March 2004 around the South Waziristan capital of Wana, some 20 kilometres from the border with Afghanistan. As part of the US-led "war on terror", the Pakistani army launched attacks to eradicate remnants of the Taliban and al-Qaeda in Afghanistan believed to be hiding in the area. The army operations in turn triggered armed resistance by local tribesmen. During the offensive, some 70,000 troops were deployed in the border region and between 5,000 and 7,500 troops were directly involved in the fighting (AI, 1 April 2004).

The use of both light and heavy artillery against the militants and an intensive search for collaborators among the civilian population led to many civilian casualties and the demolition of hundreds of houses, and forced thousands to flee their homes. Estimates of the number of people forced out by the military and paramilitary troops during the March operation vary, with some saying the number of displaced was at least 30,000. Amnesty International reported that a wide range of human rights violations were committed during the two-week operation (IRIN, 8 September 2004; Al Jazeera, 20 March 2004; AI, 1 April 2004).

A peace agreement was signed with local tribes in April 2004, but collapsed in June when Pakistani authorities maintained that certain clans in South Waziristan were still protecting foreign Islamist fighters. Clashes erupted again around the mountainous areas of Shakai, Santoi and Mantoi close to the border with Afghanistan, leading to displacement of thousands of people (IRIN, 8 September 2004; Dawn, 14 July and 20 July 2004). One newspaper reported that 12,000 people fled to North Waziristan during this period (The News, 10 July 2004; IRIN, 19 August 2004).

Military operations continued especially in areas inhabited by the Mahsuds, leading to an unknown but massive displacement of civilians. Mahsud families fled to the Frontier Region Jandola or further away to Tank, Dera Ismail Khan and Karachi, which has the largest concentration of ethnic Pashtuns in Pakistan. As of September 2004, one estimate said that up to 50,000 people had been internally displaced by the fighting in South Waziristan (BBC, 24 September 2004). A fact-finding mission by the Peshawar High Court Bar Association (PHCBA) in September 2004 also concluded that thousands were displaced, apart from civilian casualties and human rights abuses (Dawn, 22 September 2004). Closure of camps for Afghan refugees was also part of the operation in order to destroy possible hiding places for militants. A peace agreement was signed with the Mahsuds in February 2005, but tensions continued to run high in the region.

In April 2005, the United States stated that foreign fighters were still infiltrating Afghanistan from Pakistan and asked Pakistani authorities to reinforce military action against remnants of Taliban and al-Qaeda operating from bases in Waziristan (Mir, 2 May 2005).

During 2005, the Pakistani government switched the focus from South to North Waziristan where officials claimed up to 1,000 militants were protected by local tribes. The government also sent more troops to the border region, increasing the total number to 80,000. Hundreds of civilian casualties, including women and children, have been reported as a result of the fighting.

Thousands of people were reported to flee fighting around the town of Miranshah in North Waziristan during March 2006 as a result of military operations against militant positions around the city. Most of the displaced returned to their homes after two weeks (Reuters, May 2006). Many more are likely to have been displaced due to army operations during the course of 2005 and 2006, but no other information has been found about their numbers and living conditions. Information-gathering is also complicated by the fact that the displaced often live with relatives and friends. In September 2006, the Pakistani government concluded a ceasefire with pro-Taliban militants in North Waziristan, but violence has continued on several occasions (COE-DMHA, 5 and 21 September 2006).

Little is known about the conditions for returnees. While blocking all journalists and humanitarian organisations from entering, Pakistani military authorities have denied all reports of a humanitarian crisis and displacement in Waziristan and say there is a proper framework for providing assistance to the affected population. Also, the authorities have consistently denied the shortage of food or items of daily use that has been reported by the media.

Massive displacement reported from Balochistan

Balochistan is the largest of Pakistan's four provinces. It covers 43 per cent of its land area, but is inhabited by only six per cent of Pakistan's population, or around 8 million people. The Baloch make up 54.7 per cent of the population while 29 per cent are Pashtun. Although Balochistan is Pakistan's richest province in terms of energy and mineral resources, it is the most under-developed province, with half of its population living below the poverty line.

Sources: ICG, September 2006; IRIN, 26 April 2006

Tension has been simmering for decades in Pakistan's south-western Balochistan province. Tribal militants in the area have been demanding greater political autonomy and protesting against the fact that natural resources in the province are controlled by the federal government while the region receives only what they perceive as minor royalties or compensation. While the province accounts for 36 per cent of Pakistan's gas production, close to half of Balochistan's households live without electricity, for example.

While local militant groups have clashed with government forces since the 1970s, the current unrest has intensified during 2005 and 2006. The Pakistani army has launched a major offensive, particularly against the Bugti, Marri and Mengal tribes, each believed to be controlling thousands of militiamen. However, the local political support for the uprising goes far beyond these three tribes (Saghal, 1 June 2006; ICG, 14 September 2006, p.10). The first reports about major displacement due to fighting appeared in April 2005 when some 300 government troops were surrounded by thousands of tribal militants in the town of Dera Bugti, located close to Pakistan's largest gas reserves. The fighting was reported to have displaced around 6,000 people and killed scores of civilians (COE-DMHA, 29 April 2005; ICG, 14 September 2006, p.8). Militants have continued to target gas pipelines, railway lines and electricity networks, and have launched rocket attacks on government buildings and army bases, followed by retaliation and search operations by the military (Reuters, May 2006). The security situation for the civilian population has severely worsened due to the use of landmines in parts of the Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts both by rebel forces, in particular the Balochistan Liberation Army, and by the Pakistani army. As of April 2006, more than 50 civilians had been killed by landmine explosions since the beginning of the year (IRIN, 26 April 2006). The army has used heavy artillery and launched air strikes against insurgent bases; this has also killed and maimed civilians. By December 2005, about 90 per cent of the population in the town of Dera Bugti was reported to have fled and displacement was also reported in the district of Kohlu. During subsequent fighting, thousands of civilians were reported to have fled several areas in the neighbouring Jaffarabad and Sibi districts (AHRC, 21 July 2006).

The situation deteriorated further in the wake of the killing of Baloch tribal leader Nawab Akbar Khan Bugti in August 2006 which was followed by bloody riots. Several have warned that the conflict will go on escalating if the government continues its harsh military response against political opposition groups in the region (ICG, 14 September 2006).

There are no official or UN estimates of the extent of the displacement due to the fighting. One regional human rights organisation says 200,000 people were displaced as of July 2006. The displaced had at that point fled to relief camps or towns in safe areas of Jaffarabad, and the Nasirabad, Quetta and Khuzdar districts of Balochistan, as well as to the Sindh and Punjab provinces (AHRC, 21 July 2006). No other source has verified this figure. Another media report says 50,000 remained displaced due to military operations as of July 2006 (Dawn, 13 July 2006).

By early summer 2006, President General Pervez Musharraf said that life had returned to normal in Dera Bugti and that those displaced by the violence were now returning to their homes. No reports have been found on the number and conditions of return, however. In July 2006, military operations were still reported to be affecting more than 15 districts in Balochistan. Also, the government has been accused of deliberately fuelling unrest in the violence-affected area by supporting local tribes who are in conflict with the Bugtis (AHRC, 21 July 2006; IPCS, 28 June 2006).

Several reports have testified to the critical living conditions for the displaced who moved to relief camps as well as a general apathy demonstrated by the Pakistani authorities vis-à-vis the displaced civilian population. Although the media have not been allowed to move freely in the areas most affected by the violence, deplorable conditions and lack of assistance to the displaced in relief camps have been reported since the onset of the conflict. In May 2006, assistance had not yet reached the camps. The displaced were reported to be living in the open in baking hot weather without food and other facilities. Provincial opposition leaders appealed to international and national humanitarian organisations for assistance (IRIN, 26 April 2006; Dawn, 16 April 2006). The displaced were still reported to be living in temporary settlements without provision for water, sanitation, food, schooling and health care. A local human rights group reported that the displaced had to carry water from at least one to three kilometres away. No medical help was being provided to them. Most of the displaced are children and women and they are reported to suffer from diarrhoea, dehydration and malaria. Some cases of deaths have been reported but not confirmed by any hospitals (IRIN, 31 August 2006; AHRC, 21 July 2006).

The government is accused of deliberately blocking access to the displaced populations and has stopped efforts to provide health services in the camps. Official sources said to a newspaper that the displaced were well off and not in need of assistance (Dawn, 13 July 2006).

Internal displacement in Pakistan-administered Kashmir

Pakistani-controlled Kashmir is divided into the Northern Areas with a population of 1.5 million under direct Pakistani administration, and in the south Azad Kashmir with a population of 2.8 million. The latter is often also referred to as Azad Jammu and Kashmir (AJK), and enjoys a certain level of autonomy, although it is still technically under Pakistani government control.

Source: Knudsen 2002, p.34

Cross-border shelling due to the dispute over Kashmir between India and Pakistan used to be the main reason for conflict-induced displacement in Pakistan. Estimates of the number of displaced due to the fighting vary, but it is documented that at least 50,000 were displaced due to the

conflict both in Azad Kashmir and in the Northern Areas (IRIN, 3 February 2005; IR, 12 June 2002).

The territorial dispute with India over Kashmir has been the root cause of displacement in Pakistani-controlled Kashmir. Pakistan did not recognise Kashmir's accession to India in 1947 and sticks by the 1948 UN decision that the mainly-Muslim Kashmiris themselves should be allowed to decide whether to opt for India, Pakistan or independence. This has been the cause for two wars, in 1947–48 and 1965, and a period of intensified fighting in 1971. In 1972, the Line of Control was demarcated as an official ceasefire line. Since then, the two countries have mobilised for war on four occasions (1986-87, 1990, 1999 and 2002). Each time war has been avoided after international diplomatic efforts. However, despite repeated ceasefires, regular exchanges of artillery fire across the Line of Control have caused thousands to flee their homes on both sides.

A ceasefire between India and Pakistan concluded in 2003 has encouraged thousands of displaced in Pakistani-controlled Kashmir to return to their home villages. An HRCP fact-finding mission in August 2005 found that some people displaced during the 1999 conflict were still living in camps in other parts of the Northern Areas (HRCP, January 2006).

On 8 October 2005, an earthquake measuring 7.6 on the Richter scale struck northern Pakistan and affected large tracts of Pakistan-administered Kashmir and the North West Frontier Province (NWFP), displacing millions of people. The earthquake left some 73,000 people dead and two million people in need of relief and rehabilitation. Over 300,000 displaced people spent the winter in relief camps. As of September 2006, this number had been reduced to 35,000 people, a number which is expected to rise again with the onset of winter. Most of the remaining displaced have become landless due to the earthquake and landslides, or they have physical handicaps (IRIN, 7 September 2006; COE-DMHA, 21 September 2006).

Humanitarian Access

Journalists, humanitarian actors and observers have consistently been denied access to violence-affected areas in Pakistan. After the army launched attacks against the militant hide-outs in Waziristan in March 2004, access to the affected population was categorically denied (OneWorld South Asia, 26 March 2004). The International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC) did a small-scale humanitarian assessment, but could not draw any conclusions as large areas were inaccessible (IRIN, 19 August 2004).

In Balochistan, there are reports that the government has denied access to the displaced populations also for local organisations who wanted to secure medical facilities in the relief camps (Reuters 2006; AHRC, 21 July 2006).

Sectarian violence increases risk of displacement

Another worrying development is the rise of sectarian violence in Pakistan. Amnesty International reports that over recent years, hundreds of people have died in attacks carried out by different Muslim sects or groups on each other and by the Muslim majority against members of religious minorities (AI, 16 April 2006). Such violence could lead to further displacement in the country unless steps are taken to protect religious minorities from persecution. Attacks against the Shia minority by Sunni extremist groups have increased sharply, as have attacks against the Hindu, Christian and Ahmadi religious communities. Shia groups have also been responsible for several episodes of religiously motivated killings (ICG, 18 April 2005; AI, 16 April 2006). Within the first

five months of 2005, 120 civilians lost their lives, and 286 were injured in 30 incidents of sectarian violence (Mir, in SAIR, 6 June 2005).

Development-induced displacement

Development-induced displacement is on the rise in Pakistan, with several large dam projects in the pipeline. In Azad Kashmir, the raising of the height of the Mangla Dam may displace up to 44,000 people. The government says the affected population will be compensated by a package including building of new towns and cash assistance. Other forthcoming projects include the Chotiari Dam project in the Sanghar district of Sindh province and development projects in the Gwadar area which may displace 70,000 people. At the same time, the issue of compensation for those affected by previous development projects such as the building of the Mangla Dam nearly four decades ago, and the Tarbela Dam in the 1970s, remains unresolved.

The Human Rights Commission of Pakistan has recommended that a survey should be launched to assess the precise numbers of those displaced by development schemes or natural disasters so that a strategy to rehabilitate them can be finalised, and that compensation must be adequate (HRCP, February 2005, pp. 287-288).

National and international responses

The Pakistani government does not have a national policy addressing conflict-induced displacement, and does not even recognise the fact that thousands of people have fled from their homes due to fighting in Balochistan and Waziristan. There have been no reports of any systematic governmental assistance to the internally displaced.

However, there are several previous examples of government support to IDPs. People displaced due to conflict with India in Pakistan-controlled Kashmir were entitled to a modest monthly cash payment and were provided with short-term life-saving assistance by Pakistani authorities, although longer-term humanitarian aid was insufficient and sporadic. The government has also been providing assistance to IDPs after natural disasters such as the Kashmir earthquake.

The ICRC is one of the few international humanitarian organisations which has focused on the conflict-affected populations in Pakistan. In Kashmir, ICRC carried out food and non-food item distribution, monitoring, shelter assistance, support during the return phase and promoted the permanent solutions. Between 2000 and 2003, ICRC provided assistance to five IDP camps housing 5,200 people (Exchange of information with ICRC, June 2005). As for Waziristan, international aid agencies have expressed concern about the situation, but all requests to carry out independent assessments have been denied by the Pakistani authorities on security grounds. UNHCR has made it clear that it is not willing to assist the internally displaced from South Waziristan, arguing that this falls under the responsibility of the Pakistani government (Daily Times, 19 August 2004).

The plight of the conflict-affected populations during the years of conflict with India was largely ignored by the international aid community. Fewer than 50 military observers from the UN Military Observer Group in India and Pakistan (UNMOGIP) monitor the Line of Control. This UN presence, however, was never accompanied by UN humanitarian assistance, either in Pakistani- or in Indian-controlled areas (ICG, June 2004).

In order to minimise the suffering of the civilian population hit by internal conflict, the Pakistani government has to recognise its responsibility and ensure an adequate response. The

government should as soon as possible address the humanitarian situation, ensure that a survey is undertaken to map the extent of problems facing the displaced and allow aid agencies to start operations targeting the conflict-affected population.

CAUSES AND BACKGROUND

Displacement in Waziristan

Hunt for pro-Taliban militants has displaced thousands (May 2006)

- The Pakistani army has based 80,000 troops in Waziristan to flush out foreign pro-Taliban militants hiding there
- Displacement has been reported since March 2004, when the army stepped up its operations in South Waziristan
- In 2005, the government launched operations also in North Waziristan
- Despite a peace agreement between the Pakistani Government and pro-Taliban tribal leaders in September 2006, fighting has continued

Reuters, May 2006:

"Since the U.S.-led invasion of Afghanistan in 2001, the Pakistani army has launched a series of attacks in the semi-autonomous region of Waziristan, aimed at flushing out foreign pro-Taliban militants hiding there. This has led to displacement and alienation of the local population, provoking a rise in Islamic fundamentalism.

[...]

Pakistan's semi-autonomous tribal belt has become a hideout for sympathisers of the militant al Qaeda network and members of the Taliban who fled Afghanistan after U.S.-led forces toppled the regime in 2001.

Al Qaeda leader Osama bin Laden, who is blamed for the Sept. 11 attacks on U.S. cities in 2001, is believed to have passed through North Waziristan during his escape from Afghanistan that year. He and his number two, Ayman al-Zawahri, may still be hiding in the region.

In 2005, the government switched its campaign to rid the tribal areas of foreign fighters from South Waziristan to North Waziristan. Pakistani intelligence officials estimate there are up to 1,000 militants in the area, who enjoy the support of its deeply religious and conservative tribes.

The government bombing of an alleged militant hideout in early March 2006 sparked violent clashes. Several hundred militants seized government buildings in the town of Miranshah, leading to confrontations in which more than 120 militants died, according to the military. Thousands of people fled as helicopter gunships pounded militant positions around the town.

These clashes coincided with a visit to Pakistan by U.S. President George Bush. The U.S. regards Pakistan as a key ally in its "war on terror", but Bush said more needed to be done to defeat al Qaeda and pro-Taliban militants on the Pakistan-Afghan border.

Relations over border issues are thorny. Afghan officials have complained that, since 2001, insurgents have used Pakistani soil to launch attacks inside Afghanistan. A major row blew up around the time of Bush's visit when Musharraf said intelligence on Taliban leaders handed over by Afghanistan was out of date.

Several weeks later, however, Pakistan beefed up troops deployed in the area, posting more forces opposite the eastern Afghan province of Kunar to stop militants fleeing a U.S.-led offensive. There are now around 80,000 Pakistani soldiers patrolling the border area.

The death toll from the violence has reached around 375 since the middle of last year, including 325 militants (75 foreign) and around 50 members of the security forces, according to government estimates. At least half the deaths have occurred since early March 2006."

RFE/RL, 24, March 2006

"The issue of a Pashtun national homeland along the Afghan-Pakistan border has been largely dormant for the last 40 years. Dormant -- but unresolved. And now, arguments from the century-old debate are surfacing again in a way that affects the international war against terrorism.

For many ethnic Pashtuns, "Pashtunistan" is an historic homeland that was divided in 1893 by the Durand Line -- a 2,450 kilometer demarcation line drawn by the British through Pashtun tribal lands to suit the defensive needs of British colonial India.

For Islamabad, the issue represents a territorial claim against Pakistan -- particularly parts of Pakistan's Baluchistan Province and the tribal regions where Pakistani security forces are battling pro-Taliban militants. The reason is that Pakistan inherited the Durand Line from British colonial India as its northwestern border with Afghanistan."

COE-DMHA, 5 September 2006:

"The Pakistan government has reportedly signed a peace agreement with pro-Taliban militants in the country's semi-autonomous western Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA), which border Afghanistan.

[...]

Pro-Taliban militants in the area were reportedly consolidating their political power in the region, which led to a renewed military crackdown in March. According to officials in July, over 400 people have been killed in clashes this year, mostly in North Waziristan tribal agency. However since June, the government has been working with a council of tribal elders (jirga) to talk with militants to control the violence. The formation of the jirga is the first of its kind since Pakistan deployed about 80,000 troops to the region in 2003 to flush out al Qaeda and Taliban elements in the region. Under the agreement, the Pakistan military has pledged to end major operations in the area and withdraw most soldiers to military camps. According to reports today, hundreds of soldiers were withdrawn from several checkpoints in North Waziristan over the weekend. However, the military will continue to operate border checkpoints. Earlier, the military had released a number of tribesmen in what was seen as a goodwill gesture. In return, pro-Taliban militants have pledged not to shelter foreign militants, launch raids across the Afghan border or attack Pakistan government troops or infrastructure. All foreign militants would also have to respect the peace deal, otherwise they would have to leave, and movement across the border will only continue for family or business matters. Observers say that these conditions would be difficult to enforce as the Taliban has support from the Pashtun ethnic group, which live on both sides of the porous border. Across the border in Afghanistan, a recent major offensive by NATO-led forces in the southern Afghan province of Kandahar has pushed Taliban fighters to the border. Afghanistan has complained that Pakistan is not doing enough to crack down on militants on its side of the border."

Displacement in Balochistan

Background: the conflict between Baloch tribes and the government is deepening (September 2006)

- Balochistan has seen decades of struggle between separatists and the government
- In December 2005, the conflict flared up, and the army stepped up operations against separatist groups
- Thousands of civilians have been affected by the conflict

- The situation deteriorated further after one of the most influential local leaders was killed in August 2006

Reuters, May 2006

"In Baluchistan, the largest and poorest of Pakistan's four provinces, the conflict is an ethno-nationalist struggle between separatists and the government. Tribal militants have staged several insurgencies since the mid-20th century to fight for greater political autonomy and control over local mineral resources.

[...]

The decades-old conflict in Pakistan's southwestern Baluchistan province flared up again in December 2005, following a rocket attack during a visit by Musharraf to the town of Kohlu. This spurred the Pakistani military to launch a major crackdown against nationalist groups in the region.

Since then, militants have regularly blown up gas pipelines, railway lines and electricity transmission lines, and launched rocket attacks on government buildings and army bases. It is unclear how many people have been killed in the renewed violence, but according to the Daily Times newspaper, in April 2006, the interior minister put the death toll since the start of the year at around 160, including some 50 civilians and 75 tribesmen. Landmines planted by both militants and the security forces are responsible for a growing proportion of deaths.

Much of the violence is thought to be carried out by a group known as the Baluch Liberation Army (BLA), which has been listed as a terrorist organisation by the government. Set up in the 1970s, the BLA is the first nationalist group to be banned by Pakistan in recent years.

In May 2006, the government banned Baluch nationalist leaders from travelling outside Pakistan, including three members of parliament. The state telecommunications agency also ordered the country's internet service providers to block access to four websites containing Baluch nationalist material.

According to analyst Bansal, the Baluch nationalists know they cannot win a direct battle with the Pakistani army.

Their tactics are therefore focused on attacking the military's lines of communication and trying to widen the scope of the conflict by drawing in other groups to support them against the Punjabi elite. The Pakistani authorities have made allegations that the militants are receiving external support.

Baluchistan was not incorporated into Pakistan until 1948, when Pakistani troops moved in, forcing the Khan of Kalat, the monarch who had ruled the area under the umbrella of the British Empire, to give up hopes of independence.

In the mid-1950s, the People's Party, a new nationalist party, was launched by the Prince of Kalat, and in 1972, it joined with the National Awami Party, based in North West Frontier Province, and the Islamist Jamait-ul-Ulema-i-Islam in opposition to the centralising government of President Zulfikar Ali Bhutto.

Major conflict broke out in 1973 after the intelligence services intercepted a consignment of weapons headed for Baluchistan and Bhutto dismissed the regional government. Thousands of militants fought the national army, which targeted the Baluch tribes' livestock, their key economic asset. The insurgency dragged on until 1977, when Bhutto was overthrown and the military regime of General Zia ul-Haq arrived at a political settlement with some Baluch leaders. Some 9,000 people died in the violence.

[...]

Since then, resentment against the central government has continued to grow as infrastructure has been built to exploit the province's rich natural resources, especially gas. Development has fuelled local frustration for two key reasons.

Firstly, Baluchs feel their province is being increasingly monopolised by non-indigenous migrants attracted by its economic opportunities. Secondly, there is a widespread perception that the province does not receive a fair share of benefits from the exploitation of its natural resources.

One major infrastructure project regularly targeted by Baluch militants is the construction of a strategically important port at Gwadar. Work began on the deep-sea port and naval base in 2002, with the majority of funding coming from China.

Gwadar is on Pakistan's Arabian Sea coast near the mouth of the Persian Gulf, 400 km (250 miles) from the Strait of Hormuz and just 72 km from Iran. It is expected to become a key shipping hub at the mouth of a strategic waterway, and China's involvement in the project would help it protect its energy and security interests. This is a source of concern for the United States, India and Iran.

Although Baluchistan's citizens are not opposed to the project outright, as with other development initiatives, many believe its benefits will go largely to outsiders, and will not improve local living standards.

The port facilities and workers have been targeted in sporadic attacks since 2004 when bomb blasts and rocket attacks killed several Chinese engineers.

As well as calling for a larger dividend from local development projects and the exploitation of natural resources, Baluch militants are struggling for greater political control over their administrative affairs. In March 2006, the provincial assembly voted to form a bipartisan panel to try to make peace between the authorities and warring tribal leaders, but this has yet to yield significant results."

ICG, September 2006, pp.1-2:

"Three decades after the 1973-1977 insurrection in Balochistan, a low-level insurgency again challenges central control over the province. After almost seven years of military rule, deprived of representative participatory institutions and with their natural resources exploited by Islamabad, Baloch alienation is at an all-time high. Although regional parties and leaders are still struggling to obtain political, economic and social rights within a democratic, federal, parliamentary framework, militants have picked up the gun.

Baloch political parties and militants have a common goal – to assert provincial control over Balochistan's natural resources and gain a voice in shaping its political, economic and social development. "We want to live as an equal partner in the federation, with our democratic rights respected, including the ownership of our resources, these resources belong to the people of Pakistan".

[...]

By refusing to negotiate Baloch demands for provincial autonomy and control over their resources and opting instead to forcibly subdue dissent – political or militant – the Musharraf government has upped the stakes. Islamabad might be able to retain central control through brute force but its policy directions will likely

undermine the remaining vestiges of state legitimacy in the troubled province.

That tensions between the centre and the Baloch have reached new heights under centralised authoritarian rule is not surprising. The military government's disregard for provincial autonomy has sparked the unrest.[...]

Baloch alienation is also rooted in Islamabad's longstanding neglect of the resource-rich province, which remains the poorest of Pakistan's four federal units.[...] Popular support for Baloch nationalist parties and sardars (tribal chiefs) who articulate Baloch political aspirations and social and economic demands is widespread. Musharraf's decision to sideline this regional leadership and attempt instead to consolidate central control through military force has left little space for a negotiated settlement.

[...]

In 2006, this gap has increased dangerously, particularly after the military killed Nawab Akbar Khan

Bugti, one of the most influential Baloch political leaders, on 26 August 2006. Bugti had taken to the mountains in early 2006 after his hometown of Dera Bugti was attacked and besieged by the military. He was killed in his remote mountain base in a military operation that involved the use of helicopter gunships and ground troops.[...] Yet, Islamabad denies it is conducting a military operation, insisting instead that a few tribal chiefs, threatened by its development schemes which

would undermine their hold over local power, are responsible for an insurgency limited to their tribal fiefdoms.[...] But the military government is neither the harbinger of modernisation and development, nor is Baloch resistance limited to a handful of tribal chiefs.

On the contrary, Baloch dissent has become a broad movement for political, economic and social empowerment.

[...]

Balochistan is the largest of Pakistan's four provinces. Some 347,190 square kilometres in size, it covers 43 per cent of its land area but has only around 6 per cent of its population.[...]

The ethnic make-up, according to last official estimates, is 54.7 per cent Baloch, 29.0 per cent Pashtun.⁹

It is the least developed province but rich in energy and mineral resources,[...] meeting more than 40 per cent of Pakistan's energy needs through its gas and coal reserves and accounting for 36 per cent of its total gas production. Large energy reserves remain untapped.[...] However, 46.6 per cent of households have no electricity.[...] Consistent degradation of the water supply and absence of storage systems, such as small dams, have turned much of Balochistan, with its predominantly rural population, into an arid wasteland.[...] According to the Karachi-based Social Policy and Development Centre, poverty levels are twice that of Punjab, Pakistan's largest and most prosperous province; urban unemployment is 12.5 per cent, compared to the countrywide average of 9.7 per cent; and half the population lives below the poverty line.[...]

Balochistan is strategically located. Bordering on Afghanistan and Iran,[...] it lies astride the communication

routes of South, South West and Central Asia.[...] With a 760-km coastline, Balochistan links Pakistan with the oil-rich Gulf States and the sea lanes of the Arabian Sea, close to the Strait of Hormuz through which oil tankers bound for the West and Japan must pass. This coast is particularly important to the Pakistan military. Three of its four naval bases are located there."

Fighting between separatist groups and the army has displaced tens of thousands (July 2006)

- Fighting was reported to displace tens of thousands from December onwards
- Displacement started in the town of Dera Bugti, but as fighting spread to a wider area, whole districts have been affected

IRIN, 2 February 2006:

"Fact-finding missions, sent by the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) to the Kohlu area and to Sui and Dera Bugti in December 2005 and January 2006, under the leadership of HRCP's chairperson Asma Jahangir, have found a troubling picture. The fighting has caused widespread damage to buildings, and 85 percent of the 25,000 or so people of Dera Bugti have been forced to flee the town, the commission maintains.

In the Dera Bugti area, schools have been closed for the last month. HRCP says children have not been attending them since March 2005, due to armed skirmishes between tribal militias and paramilitary troops in the area.

[...]

The HRCP team, on its visit, found what looked like a ghost town at Dera Bugti. Almost the entire population, their belongings tied atop trucks, vans, lorries or donkey carts, had left the town and shops had been closed for over a month. On the roads leading out of Dera Bugti, caravans of people could be spotted leaving, watched by security forces manning road blocks.

[...]

Meanwhile, the town of Kohlu remains under a state of siege. Entry to the area is barred, and the 12,000 or so people of the town have remained virtually cut off from the outside world since the middle of December. There have been complaints of food shortages, acute problems in taking the sick or injured to hospitals and normal life has come to a standstill. From towns near Kohlu, such as Kahan, hundreds have fled. The fact that much of the population of the area is nomadic makes it difficult to ascertain the precise number of displaced people."

Raman, 21 January 2006

"[...]. Addressing a press conference at Quetta on January 14, 2006, Malik Zahoor Shahwani, the Vice-Chairman of the Balochistan Chapter of the Pakistan Human Rights Commission, said:

[...]

- Information collected by the team revealed that 53 civilians have been killed and 132 injured during an outbreak of hostilities in the remote area from the last week of December till January 8.

- "No law permits custodial killing and no law-enforcement agency is above the law and entitled to award death sentence to citizens who are in their custody. The Government should act according to constitutional requirements and uphold rule of law to ensure protection of fundamental rights of the people. If those arrested in Dera Bugti were involved in illegal activities, they should be presented before courts for trial."

- A war like situation existed in Dera Bugti "where Government offices are empty, the district coordination officer has shifted his office to Sui, schools are not functioning and vehicles not plying and the bazaar has been closed."

- "A majority of the residents of Dera Bugti town have migrated. Only two persons out of the 250 members of the local Hindu community are still living in the town."

Eighty to eighty-five per cent of the dead and injured victims of the military operation were women and children, and a majority of them non-combatants."

AHRC, 21 July 2006:

"Due to the military operations and aerial bombardments the local population have been forced to migrate to safer parts of Balochistan as well as to the nearby borders of Sindh and Punjab provinces. The military have cordoned off Hernai area for the past several days making it impossible for people to come and go. As a result the people are without food, medicines and drinking water. The area where people have taken leave from are predominantly Mach, Kohlo, Usta Mohamad, Sibi, Dera Bugti and some parts of Hanai. The two district provinces of Sibi and Bolan are the worst affected areas of military operations as well as the aerial bombardment. These two districts cover more than 500 kilometres. The displaced are now settled in other areas such as Dera Murad, Jamali, Quetta, Khuzdar, Hub in Balochistan and Kashmore, Jackob Abad and the border areas of Larkana district in Sindh Province. In Punjab Province they have taken shelter in Dera Ghazi Khan district near Usta Mohammad village of Balochistan. According to newspaper reports the displaced are living in terrible conditions with no safe drinking water. According to a report published in the daily Dawn "It is unclear how many Bugti displaced people (DPs) actually poured into neighbouring cities and towns following the outbreak of hostilities between the warring tribesmen and the law-enforcement agencies in the early summer of last year. The Dera Bugti Nazim, Kazim Bugti, puts the number of DPs at over a hundred thousand. His assertions about the involvement of army helicopters in Dera Bugti military operations lend credence to the claims of the DPs. The accusation is stoutly denied by the government, however".

Inter-tribal feuding fuels more conflict in the region (June 2006)

- The government has encouraged the return of the Kalpars which is in conflict with the Bugti tribes
- This has been seen as a deliberate effort on the part of the government to destabilise the Bugti domination in the conflict affected area
- Fighting between the two tribes has been reported on several occasions

IPCS, 28 June 2006:

"The Bugti-Kalpar feud has intensified since 1992. While such intra-tribal clashes are part of Baloch tribal history, the two tribes had co-existed in the past; two killings in 1992 changed that situation forever. Amir Hamza, son of Kalpar leader Khan Mohammad Kalpar, was allegedly killed by Akbar Bugti in May 1992 in Dera Bugti during a local bodies' election. Accepted as their leader by all Bugti tribes, Akbar Bugti does not brook any opposition and runs the political and tribal affairs of the region like a monarch complete with imprisonments and punishments. Even today there are some Kalpars 'imprisoned' by Bugti. Prior his killing Amir Hamza was attempting to forge an alliance between the Kalpars and Masuris (another Bugti sub tribe), of which Akbar Bugti did not approve. The Kalpars retaliated in June 1992 by killing Salal Bugti, Akbar Bugti's son.

Ever since, Akbar Bugti's primary goal has been to remove the Kalpars and Masuris from the region or physically eliminate them. Besides these personal and political factors, the Kalpars claim that the Sui gas fields are located in their area, hence they should be the primary beneficiaries of its royalties, which has further infuriated Akbar Bugti.

The federal government has exploited these divisions, depending on the equations between Akbar Bugti and Islamabad. Since January 2006, the federal government has rehabilitated the Kalpars in the Dera Bugti and Sui areas to minimize Akbar Bugti's influence. Besides, there is an effort to project that the situation in Dera Bugti is returning to normalcy with the displaced willing to return. The resettled Kalpars had recently led a procession in Sui supporting Musharraf's policies.

The Bugtis are against the Kalpars' return and have been attacking them ever since the first convoy brought them back. The Bugtis are also instigating those Kalpars who support Akbar Bugti against the returnees.

[...]

Besides the intra-tribal feud, the returnees face problems over issues of settlement and security. Most of Kalpar land has been occupied by the Bugtis and reclaiming it will not be easy."

Nagesh, 8 March 2006:

"As part of its strategy to establish its writ and wrest control of areas from tribal chiefs, the government last month relocated members of the Kalpari Badlani sub tribe in Sui. According to reports from Sui, residents started leaving the town soon after the government resettled the Kalpar Badlani sub tribe. Locals said that the resettled tribals were forcing them to leave. Many have left for Dera Murad Jamali, Kandhkot and Shikarpur.

On Feb 14, Another Massuri tribesmen also returned to their homes in the Bekar region of Dera Bugti district, according to APP. A total of 67 families, comprised of 334 people made their way back to their hometown. On their arrival in Bekar, the displaced tribesmen thanked the present government as well as President Pervez Musharraf for their help and support.

Kalpar Bugtis staged a demonstration in favour of development projects in Balochistan, including the building of military cantonments, Kalpar elder Sardar Ahmudan Bugti said to media.

[...]

The protestors denounced Bugti tribe chief Nawab Akbar Bugti and accused him of detaining and torturing Kalpars in private prisons. They also accused the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) and the Alliance for the Restoration of Democracy (ARD) of being partial to the Bugtis and for ignoring the Kalpars' rights. They demanded the HRCP and ARD to visit the area and observe the Kalpars' situation, who they said were subjected to atrocities. The speakers termed the Sui cantonment a "great gift" for the people of the area. They expressed full support for the policies of President Pervez Musharraf.

[...]

Another batch of some 300 Kalpars recently left for Sui under the supervision of the Frontier Corps. "We now feel safe (in Sui) and normalcy is returning to the area after a long time," said Sardar Ahmadan Bugti. He said that over 4,000 Kalpars had now resettled in Sui and 3,000 still remained in Punjab and Sindh, adding that two to five Kalpar families were returning to the town every day

The mainstream Bugti tribe, whose tribal elders are already facing a government crackdown, accused the government of sponsoring the return of Kalpar and Masuri clans, warning that it could create a serious law and order problem in their area where Pakistan's biggest Sui Gas Field is located.

[...]

But the move is seen as fuelling more tensions and a law and order problem in the area where tribesmen are already mounting hit-and-run attacks on the security forces and government installations."

Displacement of Hindus

Hindus in Balochistan targeted and displaced (January 2006)

- Anti-Hindu violence in Balochistan has displaced thousands in previous years
- Most of the Hindus left for the province of Sindh to join the Hindu community there
- The military operations in Balochistan during 2005 displaced the remaining Hindus living in Dera Bugti

Khaled Ahmed, 21 May 2004:

"Anti-Hindu violence in Balochistan: The Friday Times reported in its issue of March 23-29, 2001, as follows: 'Hundreds of Hindus have been forced to flee their homes and cross over into Sindh. Three Hindus were reported to have been killed in the town of Chaman after clashes between Hindus attempting to protect their homes and Muslim mobs in October. Temples and homes were set ablaze and property, including Hindu shops, destroyed as the growing social intolerance assumed alarming new proportions in Balochistan. In all cases, local extremist groups played a role in triggering the attacks.

'Though the precise number of families which fled was unknown, reports suggested almost half the community of 10,000 Hindus in Lasbela had been forced to leave their homes over the year. In almost all cases, the increased activism by militant religious groups imposed new strains on relations between the majority Muslim and the Hindu communities, who had lived peacefully alongside each other for many decades. The efforts to forcibly convert the Hindus, especially female school students, had a direct role to play in violence against Hindu settlements.

[...]

Plight of Hindus of Sindh: Newsline(Dec 2000), pages 77-79, stated that 'the status of the 2.7 million Hindus in Pakistan, who are largely concentrated in Sindh, does not make for a very

encouraging picture. Despite the fact that the Hindus in Pakistan have generally maintained a low profile, the general attitude towards them is one of suspicion.

[...]

'Hindus in Pakistan have faced the greatest trials when there has been tension between India and Pakistan. Says an analyst, "From the first Indo-Pak war to the demolition of the Babri mosque in Ayodhya, Hindus in Pakistan have been perceived as enemies and persecuted." Kidnapping, extortion, and even killing are, meanwhile, common crimes perpetrated against Hindus in Sindh today.

'In Pakistan, the Dalits face different issues. Since they are part of a tiny minority that is 5 per cent of country's total population, and due to also lack of education and literacy, they continue to stick to different forms of Hinduism whatever their half-literate Gurus impart them. Caste Hindus continue their domination only in southern part of Pakistan, especially former Mirpurkhas division, where more than one million Dalits dwell as landless peasants and labourers. The Caste Hindus, though small in numbers, dominate the minority politics through support of their convert relatives and government functionaries. The incidents of atrocities and caste-based discriminations on Dalits are increasing day by day in Tharparkar - a district where 35 per cent people belong to different Dalit communities among a million people - because of growing awareness and assertiveness of the Dalits. Several hundred Dalit employees of Dalit communities were transferred to far-flung areas under different obnoxious pretexts. Cases were initiated against the Dalit political activists. Their rural folks were threatened and even disallowed to graze their livestock on government lands called Gauchar.

'Dalits also suffer in many instances from de facto disenfranchisement. During elections 2002, those unpersuaded by typical electioneering were routinely threatened and beaten by a pro-government political party strongmen in order to compel them to vote for certain candidates. Already under the thumb of local landlords and police officials, Dalit villagers who do not comply had been victimized, beaten, and harassed. In Tharparkar, violence against Dalits is normally treated as a very minor and marginal issue, even by the law-enforcement machinery, whether be it police, the prosecution, or the medico-legal fraternity or often even the judiciary. Non-registration of crimes against Dalits is one of the main problem in Tharparkar. Political influence over the police, and caste, class, religion and gender biases are rampant. It is extremely difficult for helpless Dalits to file complaints, particularly against the powerful individuals and or perpetrators. The theft of livestock of Dalits in Tharparkar is rampant as police never registers any such case. These are very few examples as to how Dalits are dealt with if they display an act to show equality. Hundreds of the incidents of caste discrimination go unreported.'"

The military operations in Balochistan during 2005 displaced the remaining Hindus living there:

Raman, 21January 2006

"Musharraf has extended his military operation to intimidate the Hindu Balochs also. The Pakistan Army, which looks upon Balochistan as a sensitive area of strategic importance because of its location, natural resources and the location of its nuclear-testing and missile-targeting grounds in the province, has been over the years forcing the Hindus either to leave for India or to shift to Sindh. After the post-Partition anti-Hindu massacres which resulted in the large-scale exodus of Hindus from the then Western Pakistan to India, Balochistan and Sindh were the only provinces still having a Hindu population of a little over a million. The Sindhi and Baloch nationalists looked upon them as their ethnic brothers and sisters and protected them.

[...]

[...] In the early 1970s, the late Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, who looked upon these Hindus as security threats, started forcing them to leave Balochistan. This policy continued under the Governments that followed. After inviting the Chinese to construct the Gwadar port and the Mekran Coastal Highway, Musharraf started forcing the remaining Hindus, whose numbers had considerably dwindled, to shift to Sindh.

[...] The Baloch Sardars took under their protection those Hindus, who resisted Musharraf's attempts to re-settle them outside Balochistan. Nearly 250 Balochs were thus enjoying the protection of the Bugtis in their area. Similarly, there were small clusters of Hindus, who were living under the protection of the Marris and the Mengals. All these Hindu Balochs are now being forced to leave Balochistan since Musharraf launched the present phase of the military operation on December 18, 2005. According to the Balochistan Chapter of the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan, the number of Hindu Balochs living in the Bugti area has come down from 250 to two."

Sectarian violence

Sectarian violence is on the increase, minorities are vulnerable (April 2006)

- Hundreds of people have died in attacks carried out by different Muslim sects or groups on each other
- Religious minorities in Pakistan, including Ahmadis, Christians and Hindus continue to be victims of religiously motivated violence
- The perpetrators of violence against minorities act largely with impunity
- Sectarian violence is on the increase

AI, 13 April 2006:

"Over recent years, hundreds of people have died in attacks carried out by different Muslim sects or groups on each other, and by the Muslim majority against members of religious minorities. The organization notes that the Government of Pakistan has consistently failed to prevent sectarian violence, despite repeated verbal undertakings to the international community and minority groups in the country that it would ensure that measures would be taken to end religious discrimination and religiously motivated violence. The government has also failed to ensure that perpetrators of such crimes are brought to justice.

The Government of Pakistan has in the past on several occasions announced steps towards ending religious discrimination and sectarian violence, but has on most occasions gone back on these after protests by religious groups. For example, the use of loudspeakers at mosques to incite violence against other religious groups or individuals of other faiths has been banned but the ban has not been enforced, thereby permitting violence to continue. In addition, several religious groups which are known to have participated in violence against those belonging to other groups, and to have incited others to commit such violent acts were banned by the government in 2002, but this ban has not been enforced.

[...]

Religious minorities in Pakistan, including Ahmadis, Christians and Hindus, also continue to be victims of religiously motivated violence. The discriminatory blasphemy laws, which criminalize the preaching and religious practice by Ahmadis, have further contributed to the atmosphere of intolerance. When the government revoked an earlier undertaking to amend these laws, many people believed that this was an indication that the government did not take the protection of religious minorities seriously. A government undertaking to remove details of religious affiliation in passports and other official documents was annulled in March 2005."

Mir, Amir, 6 June 2005:

"The sectarian war between Pakistan's Shias and Sunnis is bloody and deadly. Available figures indicate that, between January 1989 and May 31, 2005 a total of 1,784 Pakistanis were killed, and another 4,279 injured in 1,866 incidents of sectarian violence and terror across the country.

This averages out to over 100 persons per year over the past 17 years, with no end in sight. And there are some indications that the trends may worsen. Thus, 187 persons were killed and another 619 were injured in 19 incidents of sectarian violence in 2004. Within the first five months of 2005, 120 Pakistanis have already lost their lives, and 286 have been injured in 30 incidents of sectarian violence.

[...]

Sectarian conflict and violence are an unpleasant reality in Pakistan today, and are becoming more and more intense. Administrative measures taken by the Musharraf-led Government have failed to produce results so far. Analysts believe that the sectarian problem cannot be overcome by such administrative measures alone, while the state itself remains in alliance with extremist elements. The problem for General Musharraf is that it is difficult to promote the so-called *jihad* in J&K without inadvertently promoting many of the Pakistani sectarian outfits. In the process, state authority stands eroded in one way or the other. The increasing militarisation and brutalisation of the conflict shows that there are virtually no sanctuaries left - neither home, nor mosque nor hospital. Not even a jail is safe. And being innocent is not the issue. Just 'being' is enough - being Shia or Sunni, *Barelvi* or *Deobandi*. In a situation where different sectarian groups are vying to prove themselves the standard bearers of Islam, one strategy to secure prominence as a representative of 'true Islam' is obviously by displaying extreme hostility and intolerance to those designated as being 'un-Islamic' by virtue of belonging to religious minorities and minority sects."

POPULATION FIGURES AND PROFILE

Global Figures

Tens of thousands have fled conflict, but no estimate of total number of displaced (October 2006)

No estimate exists on the number of displaced due to conflict-induced displacement in Pakistan.

Reports mentioning figures of displacement exists for [Balochistan](#) and [Waziristan](#) (see information under Geographical distribution)

Geographical distribution

Differing estimates of displacement due to conflict in Balochistan (August 2006)

- As of July 2006, a national human rights organization estimated that 100,000 people were displaced in the Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts alone
- Thousands have returned, but no overview exists
- Displacement was also reported in other areas of Balochistan- one report says 200,000 were displaced in July 2006
- One local newspaper, however, reports 50,000 displaced as of July 2006 - but from Dera Bugti only

AHRC, 21 July 2006:

"Urgent help is needed for 200,000 displaced victims of military operations in Balochistan province

Due to the military operations and aerial bombardments the local population have been forced to migrate to safer parts of Balochistan as well as to the nearby borders of Sindh and Punjab provinces. The military have cordoned off Hernai area for the past several days making it impossible for people to come and go. As a result the people are without food, medicines and drinking water. The area where people have taken leave from are predominantly Mach, Kohlo, Usta Mohamad, Sibi, Dera Bugti and some parts of Hanai. The two district provinces of Sibi and Bolan are the worst affected areas of military operations as well as the aerial bombardment. These two districts cover more than 500 kilometres. The displaced are now settled in other areas such as Dera Murad, Jamali, Quetta, Khuzdar, Hub in Balochistan and Kashmore, Jakob Abad and the border areas of Larkana district in Sindh Province. In Punjab Province they have taken shelter in Dera Ghazi Khan district near Usta Mohammad village of Balochistan. According to newspaper reports the displaced are living in terrible conditions with no safe drinking water. According to a report published in the daily Dawn "It is unclear how many Bugti displaced people (DPs) actually poured into neighbouring cities and towns following the outbreak of hostilities between the warring tribesmen and the law-enforcement agencies in the early summer of last year. The Dera Bugti Nazim, Kazim Bugti, puts the number of DPs at over a hundred thousand.

His assertions about the involvement of army helicopters in Dera Bugti military operations lend credence to the claims of the DPs. The accusation is stoutly denied by the government, however".

IRIN, 31 August 2006:

"HRCP estimates that in all, 100,000 people were displaced in the Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts alone. Abdul Samad Lasi, Dera Bugti's district coordination officer, says law and order have since been restored, with thousands of people returning.

However, several thousand people, like Zubaida, continue to live in temporary settlements with no provisions for water, sanitation, food, schooling or health care."

Dawn, 13 July 2006:

"It is unclear how many Bugti displaced people (DPs) actually poured into neighbouring cities and towns following the outbreak of hostilities between the warring tribesmen and the law-enforcement agencies in the early summer of last year [spring 2005].

The Dera Bugti Nazim, Kazim Bugti, puts the number of DPs at over a hundred thousand. His assertions about the involvement of army helicopters in Dera Bugti military operations lend credence to the claims of the DPs. The accusation is stoutly denied by the government, however."

Dawn, 13 July 2006:

"According to the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan, in the current situation in Dera Bugti almost 50,000 people have fled their villages and settlements. Opposition leaders say they are living in deplorable conditions and have no access to potable water, food and other basic necessities. However, official sources assert that the government has set up camps for these DPs (displaced persons). They also state that financial help is not needed since the people who have fled Dera Bugti are very well off. While the government and some of tribal leaders remain firmly cemented in their positions, what is clear is that there is no sign of any imminent relief to a people who can at best be described as dispossessed."

Displacement after fighting starting late December 2005 reportedly displaced 90 per cent of the population in the Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts:

COE-DMHA, 27 April 2006:

"There have been no official numbers of IDPs, but Shahzada Zulfiqar, a leading political analyst in Quetta, the provincial capital, said that nearly 90 percent of the local population have left their homes in Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts to escape the crossfire. He added that both rebels and the military have mined the two districts to restrict movement."

IRIN, 26 April 2006:

"Zulfiqar added that air strikes meant to target insurgents' training camps often ended up killing and maiming civilians in Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts. "These strikes often hit the tents of nomads in the mountains, causing civilian deaths. So people are very scared and nearly 90 percent of the local population have migrated to safer places in neighbouring districts."

IRIN, 2 February 2006:

"Fact-finding missions, sent by the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP) to the Kohlu area and to Sui and Dera Bugti in December 2005 and January 2006, under the leadership of HRCP's chairperson Asma Jahangir, have found a troubling picture. The fighting has caused widespread damage to buildings, and 85 percent of the 25,000 or so people of Dera Bugti have been forced to flee the town, the commission maintains.

[...]

From towns near Kohlu, such as Kahan, hundreds have fled. The fact that much of the population of the area is nomadic makes it difficult to ascertain the precise number of displaced people. "

Thousands reported displaced due to fighting in North Waziristan (March 2006)

- Thousands reported displaced, but displacement and return movements have not been monitored

COE-DMHA, 9 March 2006:

"Although thousands of civilians have been reportedly displaced, exact numbers are difficult to procure because both foreign and local journalists are barred from the region, however, local reports say that at least 1,000 families have fled fighting in Miran Shah."

HRW, 8 March 2006:

"Thousands of civilians have fled their homes since the Pakistani army, backed by helicopter gunships, began operations to put down a rebellion in the town of Miran Shah, the capital of North Waziristan Agency, on March 3.

[...]

On March 16, 2004, army and paramilitary troops reportedly evicted between 25,000 and 35,000 civilians from the area in and around the village of Kalusha in just a few hours. They remained without shelter for the two-week-long operation and returned to find that the army had destroyed scores of homes, cattle, and crops."

BBC, 7 March 2006:

"Several hundred militants seized government buildings in Miran Shah on Saturday. It followed the bombing of an alleged militant hideout by security forces last week that killed dozens of people.

The main bazaar in the town is without electricity, and the only telephones that are working are those used by the local administration, our correspondent says.

[...]

Thousands of people have already fled Miran Shah, while many more continue to leave to escape the clashes, witnesses said.

"We were waiting for the day. It was fighting all night and we feared that we might be hit by fire from a helicopter," Mohammad Anwar, a resident who was fleeing with his family, told the Associated Press."

Displacement of Hindus in Pakistan (May 2004)

Khaled Ahmed, 21 May 2004:

"Anti-Hindu violence in Balochistan: The Friday Times reported in its issue of March 23-29, 2001, as follows: 'Hundreds of Hindus have been forced to flee their homes and cross over into Sindh. Three Hindus were reported to have been killed in the town of Chaman after clashes between Hindus attempting to protect their homes and Muslim mobs in October. Temples and homes were set ablaze and property, including Hindu shops, destroyed as the growing social intolerance assumed alarming new proportions in Balochistan. In all cases, local extremist groups played a role in triggering the attacks.

"Though the precise number of families which fled was unknown, reports suggested almost half the community of 10,000 Hindus in Lasbela had been forced to leave their homes over the year."

PATTERNS OF DISPLACEMENT

General

Balochistan: civilians fled to secure areas of balochistan as well as to the Sindh and Punjab provinces

AHRC, 21 July 2006:

"Due to the military operations and aerial bombardments the local population have been forced to migrate to safer parts of Balochistan as well as to the nearby borders of Sindh and Punjab provinces. The military have cordoned off Hernai area for the past several days making it impossible for people to come and go. As a result the people are without food, medicines and drinking water. The area where people have taken leave from are predominantly Mach, Kohlo, Usta Mohamad, Sibi, Dera Bugti and some parts of Hanai. The two district provinces of Sibi and Bolan are the worst affected areas of military operations as well as the aerial bombardment. These two districts cover more than 500 kilometres. The displaced are now settled in other areas such as Dera Murad, Jamali, Quetta, Khuzdar, Hub in Balochistan and Kashmore, Jakob Abad and the border areas of Larkana district in Sindh Province. In Punjab Province they have taken shelter in Dera Ghazi Khan district near Usta Mohammad village of Balochistan. According to newspaper reports the displaced are living in terrible conditions with no safe drinking water. According to a report published in the daily Dawn "It is unclear how many Bugti displaced people (DPs) actually poured into neighbouring cities and towns following the outbreak of hostilities between the warring tribesmen and the law-enforcement agencies in the early summer of last year. The Dera Bugti Nazim, Kazim Bugti, puts the number of DPs at over a hundred thousand. His assertions about the involvement of army helicopters in Dera Bugti military operations lend credence to the claims of the DPs. The accusation is stoutly denied by the government, however". The displaced have to carry water from at least one to three kilometers away. No medical help is being provided to them. They are mostly children and women suffering from diarrhea, dehydration, malaria and high fevers. Some cases of deaths have been reported but not confirmed by any hospitals."

PHYSICAL SECURITY & FREEDOM OF MOVEMENT

General

Balochistan: landmine accidents on the increase in violence affected areas

- A growing number of landmine accidents have been reported from Balochistan, especially from the Dera Bugti and Kohlu areas

IRIN, 14 September 2006:

"[there is] a growing number of victims of landmine blasts in the troubled province of Balochistan. The mines have been indiscriminately planted by rebel groups in many areas of the Dera Bugti and Kohlu districts, to the southeast of Quetta. The area is at the epicentre of a conflict between government forces and militias led by tribal chieftans, mainly over the province's lucrative natural resources.

[...]

According to a January 2006 statement by Pakistani Senator Sanaullah Baloch, at least 180 people have died in bombings, 122 children have been killed by paramilitary troops and hundreds of people have been arrested since the beginning of the campaign in early 2005. On 8 December 2005, the federal interior minister stated that some 4,000 people had been arrested in Balochistan since the beginning of 2005.

According to figures compiled by the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan (HRCP), which has been monitoring human rights violations in Balochistan, there have been 121 landmine blast incidents in 2006 alone. At least 78 civilians and 28 security personnel have been killed, with well over 150 people injured.

"All these incidents have taken place in the Kohlu and Dera Bugti areas," explained Farid Ahmed, provincial coordinator for HRCP in Balochistan.

[...]

There is official concern at the growing casualties from landmines in the province. Razik Bugti, a spokesman for the Balochistan provincial government, has said that: "The landmines placed by 'miscreants' endangered the lives of ordinary people who did not support militancy."

Currently, security forces deployed in the Dera Bugti area are engaged in demining major roads. However, as the conflict continues, with troop movements reported by the national press in the Kohlu district, more mines continue to be laid by rebel groups opposing the military - each one of them presenting an additional threat to the people who live in these areas of Balochistan.

The toll of dead and injured from landmine explosions is just one example of the way in which the Balochistan conflict has affected hundreds of ordinary people. In 2006 alone, according to records maintained by HRCP, there have been 190 bomb blasts in the unstable province, killing more than 60 people.

An estimated 2,114 rockets were fired in the province between January and June 2006, killing 44 security personnel and 32 civilians."

SUBSISTENCE NEEDS

General

Balochistan: displaced reported to live under extremely hard conditions (July 2006)

- No assistance has been given to the displaced in Balochistan according to one regional human rights organisation
- The report says access to water, health care and shelter is urgently needed

AHRC, 21 July 2006:

"The displaced have to carry water from at least one to three kilometers away. No medical help is being provided to them. They are mostly children and women suffering from diarrhea, dehydration, malaria and high fevers. Some cases of deaths have been reported but not confirmed by any hospitals.

The local people in these areas where displaced persons are settled, are not allowed by the intelligence agencies of Pakistan Army to help refugees. Edhi center, a local charitable organisation, has been stopped by the Pakistan Military from providing medical assistance to the affected people and from making medical camps in refugee settled areas. The main persons from Edhi center were summoned to Pakistan's capital, Islamabad by the Military intelligence and were ordered to stop medical assistance to the victims. According to the daily Dawn the displaced are lying in the open skies in summer where temperature remains at 38 to 44 degrees centigrade. The conditions of the displaced are deteriorating day by day and urgent help is needed through from international organisations working for the rehabilitation of refugees and displaced persons."

The displaced were also reported to be living under extremely difficult conditions after the violence in April 2006:

IRIN, 26 April 2006:

"With violence in parts of Pakistan's southern province of Balochistan showing no signs of abating, provincial opposition leaders have appealed to humanitarian organisations to help those displaced by the conflict.

"Since the violence has escalated, thousands of poor people have migrated from the scene of clashes between [Baloch] tribesmen and security forces in the district of Dera Bugti to neighbouring areas of Jafarabad and Naseerabad. They are living in the open in baking hot weather without food and other facilities," Kachkol Ali, leader of the opposition in the provincial assembly, said in the southern port city of Karachi.

Ali, who is also head of a regional fact-finding committee on the Baloch conflict, has asked leading national charity the Karachi-based Edhi Foundation for help to assist displaced people including children, women and the elderly.

In response the foundation has sent an assessment team into the areas of Jafarabad and Naseerabad.

"We've sent our survey team to assess the number of people affected by the conflict in terms of food, shelter, drinking water and health assistance," Faisal Edhi, a spokesman for the charity, told

IRIN from Karachi. "Once the survey teams get back in a day or so, we'll be able to say something about the situation on the ground," Edhi added.

Balochistan is home to 8 million people and is the largest but least developed of Pakistan's four provinces. Endemic violence in the province has increased over the past year as tribal groups have protested against a government they say ignores their needs while extracting energy and minerals from the resource-rich province."

HUMANITARIAN ACCESS

Humanitarian access to conflict affected areas

Balochistan: humanitarian access to conflict affected populations denied (July 2006)

- There are several reports of authorities hindering access to the conflict affected populations
- Journalists have also been barred from entering to report from the camps

AHRC, 21 July 2006:

"The local people in these areas where displaced persons are settled, are not allowed by the intelligence agencies of Pakistan Army to help refugees. Edhi center, a local charitable organisation, has been stopped by the Pakistan Military from providing medical assistance to the affected people and from making medical camps in refugee settled areas. The main persons from Edhi center were summoned to Pakistan's capital, Islam Abad by the Military intelligence and were ordered to stop medical assistance to the victims. According to the daily Dawn the displaced are lying in the open skies in summer where temperature remains at 38 to 44 degrees centigrade. The conditions of the displaced are deteriorating day by day and urgent help is needed through from international organisations working for the rehabilitation of refugees and displaced persons."

Dawn, 13 July 2006:

"The vice-president of the Jamhuri Watan Party, Rafiq Ahmed Khoso, says that not only were sophisticated weapons used against largely unprotected civilian settlements but relief workers were also turned away. "I visited many camps of DPs in Nasirabad, Jafarabad, Kashmore and other neighbouring towns. And I was told that Edhi relief volunteers were asked either to leave or operate among DPs without government security."

However, a spokesman for the Edhi Foundation says that a four-member team visited camps of DPs in Jafarabad, Nasirabad and Dera Murad Jamali about two months back and returned only when Dera Bugti's top bureaucracy chief, Abdul Samad Lasi, told them that they would be called when needed. "Mr Lasi assured us that the government would do all it could to help the DPs," says the spokesman."

Waziristan: no humanitarian access to the civilian population after army operations (September 2004)

IRIN, 8 September 2004:

"Residents of Pakistan's northwestern conflict-hit tribal belt of Wana have complained that no relief or human rights agency have acted to stem the deteriorating humanitarian situation following a military operation in the area designed to root out militants and those supporting them.

"Humanitarian organisations should have dispatched their teams and representatives to assess the loss of civilian lives, the demolition of houses, the disruption of livelihoods and the destruction of agriculture in the area," Wali Muhammad, a resident of the conflict-hit area of Shakai, told IRIN in the second largest city of North Western Frontier Province (NWFP), Dera Ismail Khan (DIK).

"We regret that no organisation has visited the area so far. They [military] bombarded our houses. Innocent children and women lost their lives but no one bothers," Muhammad said, adding, "We will show them the orchards and fields destroyed by the bombardment by the military. Only then can one have a balanced view. Otherwise there is no option except to believe the official statements.""

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